

NXG-HUB DIGITAL TECHNOLOGIES



How to Build a Tech Portfolio

That Gets You Hired in Nigeria

A practical guide for self-taught developers, designers and tech professionals who are ready to stop preparing and start getting hired.

NXG-HUB

Most self-taught portfolios do not fail because the work is bad. They fail because the story is wrong.

This book was written for one specific person: someone who has spent months, maybe years, teaching themselves a tech skill, has built things they're genuinely proud of and still can't seem to get hired.

If that is you, the problem is rarely your ability. It is how you are presenting what you can do.

Hiring managers in Nigerian tech companies make decisions fast. They open your portfolio, spend 60 seconds on it, and form a conclusion. This book is about making those 60 seconds count and making sure that every conversation, interview and application that follows goes in your favour.

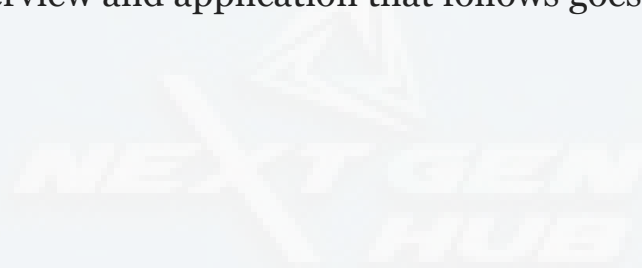


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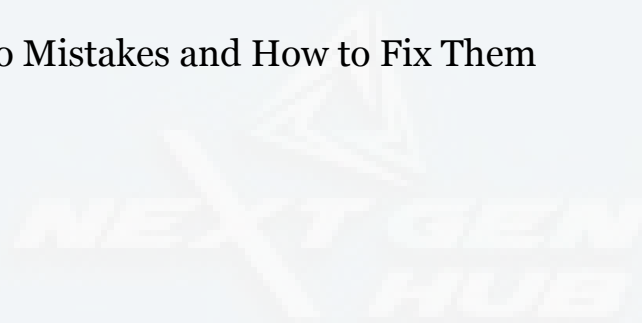
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- Why most portfolios miss the mark and the mindset shift that changes everything
- How to choose and frame projects that demonstrate real value
- How to present your work so it tells a story a recruiter can follow
- Track-specific guidance for software engineering, design, DevOps, data, product, project management, 3D graphics, digital marketing and motion design
- Where to host your work and how to make sure you're findable
- The most common portfolio mistakes and how to fix each one

Read it front to back the first time. Then come back to the chapters that apply to your track and use them as a working reference.

CHAPTER 1

What a Portfolio Is Actually For

Let's start here because most people get this wrong.

A portfolio is not a gallery or a collection of everything you have ever built, displayed in one place so people can see how busy you have been. That is an archive and an archive does not get you hired.

A portfolio is an argument. It is a structured, intentional case that you can specifically solve problems that a company cares about. Every project in it, every description you write, every link you include should be doing one job of making that argument more convincing.

Ask yourself: Does this project prove I can do the job, or does it just prove I spent time on it?

The reason this distinction matters is that hiring managers are not evaluating your effort. They are evaluating your fit. They have a problem, a product to build, a system to maintain, a campaign to run, and they are looking for someone who can credibly step in and help solve it. Your portfolio is the first place they go to find out if that person is you.

The 60-Second Test

Here is what happens when a hiring manager or recruiter opens your portfolio link. They spend about 60 seconds. In that time, they are unconsciously asking three questions:

1. **Can I tell immediately what this person does?** If your homepage requires reading three paragraphs before it's clear you're a frontend developer, you've already lost them.
2. **Does the work look like something we would use?** Not polished for its own sake, but relevant. A data analyst's portfolio full of theoretical datasets with no business context does not answer this question.

- 3. Is there a person behind this?** The best portfolios have a voice. They feel like someone made deliberate choices, not like someone followed a template.

If your portfolio does not pass this test, the rest of your application materials barely matter.

The Tutorial Project Problem

One of the most common portfolio mistakes is filling it with tutorial projects, builds that follow a course, replicate a YouTube walkthrough or clone an existing product step by step.

Tutorial projects are not bad for learning, but they are bad for portfolios.

When a hiring manager sees a Netflix clone, a to-do app, or a generic e-commerce template, what they actually see is “this person followed instructions” and that is not the same as “this person can solve a problem”.

The fix

Take the skill you learned from a tutorial and apply it to something you came up with yourself. A weather app that shows conditions for your local government area. A budget tracker built for how Nigerians actually manage money. A UI audit of a Nigerian brand's website with your own redesign. The project does not have to be large, but it has to be yours.

How Many Projects Do You Actually Need?

Well, it's fewer than you think. Two or three strong, well-presented projects will outperform ten average ones every time. Quality signals judgment, while quantity without quality signals that you are not yet sure what good looks like. The right number depends on your track and experience level, but as a general rule, if you would not be proud to walk a senior professional through it on a call, it should not be in your portfolio.

NXG

In the NXG-HUB Job Shadowing Program, participants work on live NXG-HUB projects from week one — not simulations, not replicas of existing products. By the end of 12 weeks, every participant has real, professional work they can point to in a portfolio conversation. That's the difference between work you built and work you did

CHAPTER 2

Choosing the Right Projects

The projects you choose to include in your portfolio make or break it. Not because of how impressive they are, but because of how relevant and how intentional they are.

Here's a framework for thinking about it.

Start With the Job Description, Not Your Work

Before deciding what to include, find three to five job descriptions for the kind of role you want. Read them carefully, note the skills they keep asking for, the tools they mention and the outcomes they describe.

Now look at your existing projects through that lens. Which ones demonstrate the skills those job descriptions are asking for? Those are your portfolio projects. The rest are supporting material or they get cut.

Practical example

If every frontend developer role you are targeting mentions React, accessibility and responsive design, and your strongest project uses vanilla JavaScript with no accessibility considerations, then that is not your lead project. It might still be worth including as a secondary piece, but your lead project should directly address what the market is asking for.

Real Use Cases Over Impressive Complexity

A simple project that solves a real problem will always outperform a technically complex project that solves nothing in particular.

What makes a use case "real"? It means someone, even a hypothetical someone, would actually want to use it. It means there is a problem being solved, not just a feature being demonstrated.

- A school fees payment tracker for a Nigerian secondary school parent is a real use case

- A CRUD app with no defined user or purpose is not
- A UX redesign of a Nigerian government portal with identified pain points is a real use case
- A redesign of the same portal because "it looks outdated" is not

The difference is intent. Real use cases start with a problem and build from there.

The Rebuilding Strategy

If you do not yet have strong projects, you don't necessarily have to start over. Look at what you have built already and ask, *"Can I rebuild this with a defined use case and a better presentation?"*

Take your existing to-do app, add a specific user managing multiple income streams. Add a specific problem, i.e., keeping track of daily expenses across gig work, a side business and a primary job. Rebuild it with that context in mind and document the process. Now you have a real use case project.

Same skill level but a completely different portfolio value.

Building Without a Client

The most common objection at this stage is: "I don't have any clients yet, so how do I get real projects?"

You don't need a client to build something real. Some options that can actually work:

- **Self-imposed briefs:** Write a brief for yourself. Define a user, a problem, a constraint and a success metric, and then solve it. This is exactly what design sprints, hackathons and product exercises do.
- **Community or local problems:** Is there a local business, school, church or community organisation that has a digital problem? Offer to build a solution. You get real context and they get something useful.
- **Open datasets:** Nigerian open data sources, NERC, NBS and CBN, provide real datasets with real context. A data analysis built on Nigerian economic data is immediately more relevant to a Nigerian employer than one built on a generic Kaggle dataset.

- **Contribute to open source:** Even small contributions to active open-source projects demonstrate professional coding standards, collaboration and real-world codebase familiarity.

**NXG**

The NXG-HUB Job Shadowing Program removes this problem entirely. Participants are assigned to live NXG-HUB projects — real clients, real deliverables, real stakes. It's the fastest way to build portfolio-worthy professional work without having to find it yourself.

CHAPTER 3

How to Present Each Project

You can have the best project in the room and still lose the opportunity because of how you have presented it. Presentation is not decoration, It is communication.

Every project in your portfolio needs to answer three questions clearly and quickly

What was the problem? What did you do? What changed because of it?

That's it. If your project description does not answer all three, it's incomplete regardless of how good the work itself is.

Writing Project Descriptions That Work

Most portfolio descriptions read like a CV dump. "Built a responsive e-commerce website using React and Node.js with MongoDB database integration." This tells a hiring manager what tools you used. It does not tell them why it matters.

Compare that to "Nigerian food vendors were losing customers because their order process only worked on WhatsApp and couldn't scale. I built a lightweight ordering system that reduced order processing time by 40% and could be managed from a basic Android phone."

Same project, but a completely different story.

The Three-Part Project Structure

1. **The Problem:** One to two sentences. What existed before you started? Who was affected and how? Be specific, as vague problems produce vague impressions.
2. **Your Process:** Two to three sentences. What decisions did you make and why? What constraints did you work within? This is where you show thinking, not just execution.
3. **The Result:** One to two sentences. What changed? What can someone do now that they couldn't before? If you have a number, adoption rate, time saved or error reduction, use it.

On metrics - Not every project will have measurable outcomes. That's fine. "The client used this to onboard 30 new customers in the first month" is a result. "The redesign tested positively with 8 out of 10 user testers" is the result. Even qualitative outcomes count, just be specific.

Screenshots, Live Links, and Case Studies

The format you use depends on your track, but the principle is the same. Show, don't just tell.

- Live URL is the gold standard where applicable. A working product is the strongest evidence.
- Screenshots with captions are useful when a live URL is impossible. Captions should describe what the viewer is looking at and why it matters, not just label it.
- Video walkthrough is increasingly useful, especially for interactive products, motion work or 3D renders. Keep it under 3 minutes. Narrate your decisions.
- Case study documents are essential for UI/UX, product management and any role where process matters as much as output. Walk through the thinking, not just the result.

What Not to Include

Some things that consistently hurt portfolios.

- Unfinished projects with visible placeholder content
- Projects you can't speak to in detail. If you can't explain it, remove it

- Overly long descriptions that bury the point in paragraph four
- Generic stock images used as project visuals, they signal a lack of investment
- Projects listed without any context or description at all

**NXG**

One of the things participants in the NXG-HUB Job Shadowing Program gain is the experience of presenting work to professionals — getting feedback on how their work is communicated, not just how it was built. That feedback loop is hard to replicate outside of a professional environment.

CHAPTER 4

Track-Specific Portfolio Guidance

The fundamentals of a strong portfolio are the same across every tech track, real projects, clear presentation and honest context. But what "strong" looks like varies significantly depending on what you do.

This chapter covers the specific things that matter most for each track, using the nine tracks that broadly represent where self-taught professionals in Nigeria are most actively building careers.

Software Engineering (Frontend & Backend)

- Your GitHub is your portfolio. Keep it active, organised and public.
- Write READMEs that explain what the project does, why it exists and how to run it. A project without a README signals you don't think about the next person.
- At least one project should be live at a URL. A deployed application is worth ten screenshots.
- Code quality matters. Hiring managers do look at your code. It should be readable, consistently formatted and logically structured.
- Version control habits are visible. Commit messages like 'fixed stuff' or 'final final v2' signal a lack of professional discipline.
- Full-stack projects carry more weight than single-layer projects. At the entry level, they demonstrate a broader understanding of how systems connect.

Product Design (UI/UX)

- Visuals alone will not get you hired. The thinking behind the visuals is what separates junior designers from candidates who get offers.
- Your strongest piece should be a full case study. User research, problem definition, ideation, iterations, final design and if possible, feedback or outcomes.
- Share your Figma files with view access. Keeping them locked signals you're not confident in the work.
- Show your process artefacts. Wireframes, user flows, empathy maps and early sketches. These prove that your final design is not just an aesthetic preference.
- Critique your own work inside the case study. "In retrospect, I would have tested this assumption earlier" shows more maturity than a portfolio with no self-reflection.

DevOps

- DevOps portfolios are rarer and therefore more distinctive. A well-documented GitHub presence here stands out significantly.
- Show infrastructure-as-code: Terraform files, Kubernetes configs, CI/CD pipeline setups with documentation.
- Walk through at least one end-to-end deployment pipeline you built and explain every decision.
- Incident documentation is underused and highly valued. Describe a problem you diagnosed, how you approached it and what you changed as a result.

- Monitoring and observability are often overlooked in self-taught DevOps portfolios. Even a basic Prometheus/Grafana setup documented well signals professional awareness.

Data Analysis

- The goal of a data portfolio is to show that you can transform raw information into a conclusion that someone would care about.
- Use Nigerian or African datasets where possible. Analysing CBN monetary policy data or NBS consumer price index data is immediately more relevant to a Nigerian employer than a generic Titanic dataset.
- Jupyter Notebooks should be clean and annotated. Someone unfamiliar with your analysis should be able to follow it.
- Publish dashboards on Tableau Public, Power BI, or Google Looker Studio. Interactive visualisations demonstrate both analytical and communication skills.
- Every project should end with an insight or recommendation, not just a chart. Data without a so-what is incomplete work.

Product Management

- Product Management portfolios are about structured thinking, not shipping. Show documents that demonstrate how you make decisions.
- A Product Requirements Document (PRD) or a product brief is the minimum entry point. Make it real, even if the product is hypothetical, the thinking should be rigorous.

- Feature prioritisation exercises with a defined framework (RICE, MoSCoW, ICE) demonstrate that you can make decisions under constraints.
- User research documentation, even lightweight interview notes or survey summaries, demonstrates customer empathy.
- Business awareness is the differentiator. Products exist to solve business problems. Show you understand the business context, not just the user experience.

Project Management

- Project management portfolios should demonstrate control over complexity, timelines, risks, stakeholders and communications, all of which should be documented and accounted for.
- A work breakdown structure or a project plan from a real or simulated project is the foundation. Make it detailed.
- Show a risk register with actual mitigations, not a generic template.
- Stakeholder communication samples (update reports, escalation summaries, meeting notes) demonstrate professional communication skills.
- Methodology fluency matters. Show that you can work in Agile, Waterfall, or a hybrid approach and know when each is appropriate.

3D Graphics

- Your showreel is your entire portfolio. It should be 60–90 seconds of your absolute best work, cut to a pace that demonstrates confidence.
- Show range within a focused style. Modelling, texturing, lighting and rendering in the same reel demonstrates technical breadth.
- Every piece in your reel or portfolio should have context: what it was for, what the constraints were and what software and render engine you used.
- File naming and project organisation matter more than most 3D artists realise. A hiring manager who asks for your source files should receive something professional, not a folder of untitled exports.
- Brief-based work carries more weight than personal exploration. A project with defined objectives shows you can work to someone else's requirements.

Digital Marketing

- Anyone with a phone can post content. Your portfolio needs to show strategy, measurement, and results, not just content.
- Campaign case studies are the most powerful portfolio piece: objective, audience, strategy, execution, results and learnings.
- Use real metrics where possible. Reach, engagement rate, cost per result and conversion rate, numbers make vague claims concrete.
- Demonstrate platform fluency. Screenshots of Meta Ads Manager, Google Analytics, or a campaign dashboard show hands-on experience rather than theoretical knowledge.

- Writing quality matters. Ad copy, email sequences and content strategy documents. All this shows how well you communicate, which is the core skill in marketing.

Motion Design

- A 60–90 second showreel of your strongest work is non-negotiable. Lead with your best piece, not your most recent one.
- Timing, easing and composition are what separate motion designers from people who know the software. Make sure your reel shows all three.
- Brief-based work, whether from a client, a self-imposed brief or a course project with constraints, is stronger than unconstrained personal experimentation.
- Show your process where possible. Style frames, storyboards or iteration screenshots demonstrate that your final output is not a lucky accident.
- List your tools clearly. After Effects, Premiere Pro, Cinema 4D, DaVinci Resolve... Many hirers scan for software compatibility before watching the reel.

NXG

The NXG-HUB Job Shadowing Program runs across all nine of these tracks. Participants don't build hypothetical work — they contribute to real NXG-HUB deliverables under the guidance of professionals who work in these fields every day. The portfolio output from 12 weeks of real work is categorically different from anything built in isolation.

CHAPTER 5

Where to Host Your Portfolio and How to Get Found

Building a strong portfolio and putting it somewhere no one looks at are two different problems. This chapter covers both.

Your Primary Portfolio Home

The best setup is a personal website on your own domain. It signals professionalism, gives you complete control over presentation and is the single link you put everywhere, on your CV, your LinkedIn, your email signature and on every application.

You don't need to be a developer to build one. Tools like Webflow, Framer, Notion and Carrd can get a clean, professional portfolio site live without writing a line of code. If you are a developer, build it yourself, as your portfolio site is itself a portfolio piece.

Domain names

firstname.com or firstnamelastname.com is the ideal. If that's taken, firstnamedev.com or firstnamedesigns.com works. Avoid long, hyphenated, or hard-to-spell domains. The goal is for someone to remember it after hearing it once.

Platform-Specific Presence by Track

Beyond your personal site, certain platforms matter significantly for specific tracks. Being present and active on the right ones increases your discoverability to Nigerian recruiters.

- GitHub is essential for Software Engineering, DevOps and Data Analysis. Your profile should be public, your pinned repositories should represent your best work, and your contribution graph should show consistent activity.

- Behance / Dribbble is relevant for Product Design and Motion Design. Behance allows full case studies, while Dribbble is better for visual-first showcasing.
- Tableau Public / Power BI Gallery is for Data Analysis. Published interactive dashboards are findable by recruiters specifically searching for analysts.
- The LinkedIn Featured Section is universally important. Every track should use this to link directly to portfolio pieces, case studies or published work.
- ArtStation is for 3D Graphics and Motion Design. This is where industry professionals and hiring managers in these fields actively seek talent.

How Nigerian Tech Recruiters Actually Find Candidates

Most Nigerian tech hiring happens through three channels, in this order:

Referrals: Someone who knows you recommends you. This is the dominant hiring channel. A strong portfolio matters here too, because when someone refers you, the hiring manager will look you up.

LinkedIn search: Recruiters search by skill, location and keywords. Your headline, skills section and About section need to contain the words they are searching for.

Direct applications: Job boards like Jobberman, MyJobMag, LinkedIn Jobs and company career pages. Your portfolio link in every application is the difference between being considered and being skipped.

The implication of this is clear. Building a great portfolio is necessary but not sufficient. You also need to be **findable**, **connectable** and highly **recommended**. That requires an active LinkedIn presence, relationships within the Nigerian tech community and consistent visibility.

NXG

Participants in the NXG-HUB Job Shadowing Program gain direct access to the NXG-HUB professional network and partner companies. The referral channel — the strongest hiring channel in Nigerian tech — becomes accessible in a way that self-study alone cannot open.

CHAPTER 6

Common Portfolio Mistakes and How to Fix Them

This chapter is a direct, honest list of the most frequent problems in self-taught portfolios in Nigeria. Read it as a checklist. If any of these apply to you, fix them before your next application.

Mistake 1: The Portfolio Is Hard to Navigate

If a visitor cannot find your work within **10 seconds** of landing on your page, they will not look for it, they will leave.

The fix: Your homepage should immediately show what you do and feature your best 2–3 projects above the fold. No long introductions, no splash screens, no music, work first.

Mistake 2: Every Project Is a Tutorial Clone

A portfolio full of Airbnb clones, Netflix clones and Twitter clones tells a hiring manager one thing - “this person can follow instructions” and that's not the bar.

The fix: Replace at least two tutorial projects with original work. Projects you conceived, defined and built yourself, even if they are simpler. Original beats “*impressive-but-copied*” every time.

Mistake 3: Projects Have No Context

A screenshot of an interface with no explanation is decoration and a GitHub repo with no README is an incomplete submission.

The fix: Every project gets a description using the three-part structure from Chapter 3. Problem, process and result. Every repository gets a README. No exceptions.

Mistake 4: The Portfolio Includes Unfinished Work

A half-built project with broken links or placeholder text signals that you don't complete what you start and hiring managers notice.

The fix: If it is not finished, it is not in the portfolio. A smaller portfolio of complete, polished work is always better than a larger one with visible holes.

Mistake 5: The CV and Portfolio Tell Different Stories

Your CV says you built five projects. Your portfolio shows two. Or your CV describes skills your portfolio does not demonstrate at all.

The fix: Treat your CV and portfolio as one document. Every skill listed on your CV should be evidenced somewhere in your portfolio. Every major project in your portfolio should appear on your CV.

Mistake 6: The Portfolio Hasn't Been Updated in Over a Year

A portfolio with projects dated two years ago and no recent activity suggests you have stopped learning. In a field that moves as fast as tech, that's a concern.

The fix: Set a calendar reminder every three months to review your portfolio. Add new work, remove anything that no longer represents your current level and keep it current.

Mistake 7: You Cannot Speak to Your Own Work

It mostly appears in interviews. You have listed a project, the interviewer asks about it and you cannot remember the details. The decisions you made, the problems you ran into and the reason you built it that way.

The fix: Before every interview, re-read your own portfolio. Walk through each project out loud, alone, until you can describe it fluently from memory. If you cannot, remove it.

**NXG**

In the NXG-HUB Job Shadowing Program, participants present their work to mentors and peers throughout the 12 weeks. That regular practice of explaining, defending, and discussing your own work is one of the most underrated forms of interview preparation available

Next Steps

What Comes After the Portfolio

A strong portfolio is the starting point, not the finish line.

Getting hired in the Nigerian tech industry requires three things working together.

1. A portfolio that proves you can do the work.
2. A professional presence that makes you findable and referable.
3. Real-world experience verifying what your portfolio claims.

The first two are in your control now. The third one is the hardest to get on your own. You cannot give yourself professional experience. Someone has to give you the work, the feedback, the standards and the accountability that comes from operating inside a real professional environment.

That is the gap the NXG-HUB Job Shadowing Program was built to close.

NXG-HUB Job Shadowing Program

12 weeks of real project experience across 10 tracks, under the guidance of industry professionals, with a direct referral pipeline to partner companies.

12 Weeks | 10 Tracks | 100 Participants | ₦100,000/\$100

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WHAT WILL YOUR NEXT STEP BE?